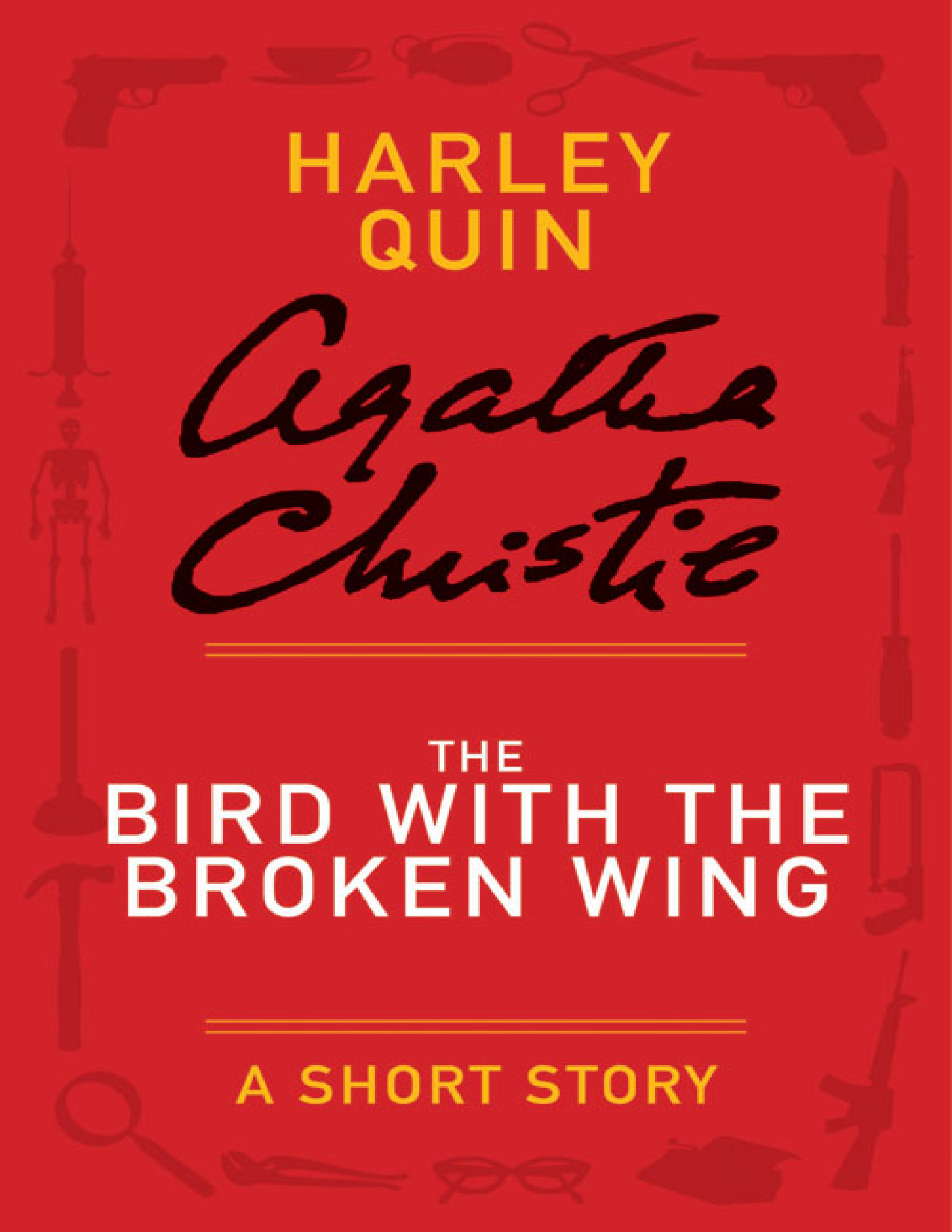




HARLEY
QUIN

*Agatha
Christie*

THE
BIRD WITH THE
BROKEN WING

A SHORT STORY

The Bird with the Broken Wing

A Short Story

Agatha Christie

WITNESS
IMPULSE

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THE BIRD WITH THE BROKEN WING

Mr. Satterthwaite looked out of the window. It was raining steadily. He shivered. Very few country houses, he reflected, were really properly heated. It cheered him to think that in a few hours' time he would be speeding towards London. Once one had passed sixty years of age, London was really much the best place.

He was feeling a little old and pathetic. Most of the members of the house party were so young. Four of them had just gone off into the library to do table turning. They had invited him to accompany them, but he had declined. He failed to derive any amusement from the monotonous counting of the letters of the alphabet and the usual meaningless jumble of letters that resulted.

Yes, London was the best place for him. He was glad that he had declined Madge Keeley's invitation when she had rung up to invite him over to Laidell half an hour ago. An adorable young person, certainly, but London was best.

Mr. Satterthwaite shivered again and remembered that the fire in the library was usually a good one. He opened the door and ventured cautiously into the darkened room.

"If I'm not in the way—"

"Was that N or M? We shall have to count again. No, of course not, Mr. Satterthwaite. Do you know, the most exciting things have been happening. The spirit says her name is Ada Spiers, and John here is going to marry someone called Gladys Bun almost immediately."

Mr. Satterthwaite sat down in a big easy chair in front of the fire. His eyelids drooped over his eyes and he dozed. From time to time he returned to consciousness, hearing fragments of speech.

"It can't be P A B Z L—not unless he's a Russian. John, you're shoving. I saw you. I believe it's a new spirit come."

Another interval of dozing. Then a name jerked him wide awake.

“Q-U-I-N. Is that right?” “Yes, it’s rapped once for ‘Yes.’ Quin. Have you a message for someone here? Yes. For me? For John? For Sarah? For Evelyn? No—but there’s no one else. Oh! it’s for Mr. Satterthwaite, perhaps? It says ‘Yes.’ Mr. Satterthwaite, it’s a message for you.”

“What does it say?”

Mr. Satterthwaite was broad awake now, sitting taut and erect in his chair, his eyes shining.

The table rocked and one of the girls counted.

“LAI—it can’t be—that doesn’t make sense. No word begins LAI.”

“Go on,” said Mr. Satterthwaite, and the command in his voice was so sharp that he was obeyed without question.

“LAIDEL? and another L—Oh! that seems to be all.”

“Go on.”

“Tell us some more, please.”

A pause.

“There doesn’t seem to be any more. The table’s gone quite dead. How silly.”

“No,” said Mr. Satterthwaite thoughtfully. “I don’t think it’s silly.”

He rose and left the room. He went straight to the telephone. Presently he was through.

“Can I speak to Miss Keeley? Is that you, Madge, my dear? I want to change my mind, if I may, and accept your kind invitation. It is not so urgent as I thought that I should get back to town. Yes—yes—I will arrive in time for dinner.”

He hung up the receiver, a strange flush on his withered cheeks. Mr. Quin—the mysterious Mr. Harley Quin. Mr. Satterthwaite counted over on his fingers the times he had been brought into contact with that man of mystery. Where Mr. Quin was concerned—things happened! What had happened or was going to happen—at Laidell?

Whatever it was, there was work for him, Mr. Satterthwaite, to do. In some way or other, he would have an active part to play. He was sure of that.

Laidell was a large house. Its owner, David Keeley, was one of those quiet men with indeterminate personalities who seem to count as part of the furniture. Their inconspicuousness has nothing to do with brain power—David Keeley was a most brilliant mathematician, and had written a book

totally incomprehensible to ninety-nine hundreds of humanity. But like so many men of brilliant intellect, he radiated no bodily vigour or magnetism. It was a standing joke that David Keeley was a real “invisible man.” Footmen passed him by with the vegetables, and guests forgot to say how do you do or goodbye.

His daughter Madge was very different. A fine upstanding young woman, bursting with energy and life. Thorough, healthy and normal, and extremely pretty.

It was she who received Mr. Satterthwaite when he arrived.

“How nice of you to come—after all.”

“Very delightful of you to let me change my mind. Madge, my dear, you’re looking very well.”

“Oh! I’m always well.”

“Yes, I know. But it’s more than that. You look—well, blooming is the word I have in mind. Has anything happened my dear? Anything—well—special?”

She laughed—blushed a little.

“It’s too bad, Mr. Satterthwaite. You always guess things.”

He took her hand.

“So it’s that, is it? Mr. Right has come along?”

It was an old-fashioned term, but Madge did not object to it. She rather liked Mr. Satterthwaite’s old-fashioned ways.

“I suppose so—yes. But nobody’s supposed to know. It’s a secret. But I don’t really mind your knowing, Mr. Satterthwaite. You’re always so nice and sympathetic.”

Mr. Satterthwaite thoroughly enjoyed romance at second hand. He was sentimental and Victorian.

“I mustn’t ask who the lucky man is? Well, then all I can say is that I hope he is worthy of the honour you are conferring on him.”

Rather a duck, old Mr. Satterthwaite, thought Madge.

“Oh! we shall get on awfully well together, I think,” she said. “You see, we like doing the same things, and that’s so awfully important, isn’t it? We’ve really got a lot in common—and we know all about each other and all that. It’s really been coming on for a long time. That gives one such a nice safe feeling, doesn’t it?”

“Undoubtedly,” said Mr. Satterthwaite. “But in my experience one can never really know all about anyone else. That is part of the interest and charm of life.”

“Oh! I’ll risk it,” said Madge, laughing, and they went up to dress for dinner.

Mr. Satterthwaite was late. He had not brought a valet, and having his things unpacked for him by a stranger always flurried him a little. He came down to find everyone assembled, and in the modern style Madge merely said: “Oh! here’s Mr. Satterthwaite. I’m starving. Let’s go in.”

She led the way with a tall grey-haired woman—a woman of striking personality. She had a very clear rather incisive voice, and her face was clear cut and rather beautiful.

“How d’you do, Satterthwaite,” said Mr. Keeley.

Mr. Satterthwaite jumped.

“How do you do,” he said. “I’m afraid I didn’t see you.”

“Nobody does,” said Mr. Keeley sadly.

They went in. The table was a low oval of mahogany. Mr. Satterthwaite was placed between his young hostess and a short dark girl—a very hearty girl with a loud voice and a ringing determined laugh that expressed more the determination to be cheerful at all costs than any real mirth. Her name seemed to be Doris, and she was the type of young woman Mr. Satterthwaite most disliked. She had, he considered, no artistic justification for existence.

On Madge’s other side was a man of about thirty, whose likeness to the grey-haired woman proclaimed them mother and son.

Next to him—

Mr. Satterthwaite caught his breath.

He didn’t know what it was exactly. It was not beauty. It was something else—something much more elusive and intangible than beauty.

She was listening to Mr. Keeley’s rather ponderous dinner-table conversation, her head bent a little sideways. She was there, it seemed to Mr. Satterthwaite—and yet she was not there! She was somehow a great deal less substantial than anyone else seated round the oval table. Something in the droop of her body sideways was beautiful—was more than beautiful. She looked up—her eyes met Mr. Satterthwaite’s for a moment across the table—and the word he wanted leapt to his mind.

Enchantment—that was it. She had the quality of enchantment. She might have been one of those creatures who are only half-human—one of the Hidden People from the Hollow Hills. She made everyone else look rather too real. . . .

But at the same time, in a queer way, she stirred his pity. It was as though semihumanity handicapped her. He sought for a phrase and found it.

“A bird with a broken wing,” said Mr. Satterthwaite.

Satisfied, he turned his mind back to the subject of Girl Guides and hoped that the girl Doris had not noticed his abstraction. When she turned to the man on the other side of her—a man Mr. Satterthwaite had hardly noticed, he himself turned to Madge.

“Who is the lady sitting next to your father?” he asked in a low voice.

“Mrs. Graham? Oh, no! you mean Mabelle. Don’t you know her? Mabelle Annesley. She was a Clydesley—one of the illfated Clydesleys.”

He started. The ill-fated Clydesleys. He remembered. A brother had shot himself, a sister had been drowned, another had perished in an earthquake. A queer doomed family. This girl must be the youngest of them.

His thoughts were recalled suddenly. Madge’s hand touched his under the table. Everyone else was talking. She gave a faint inclination of her head to her left.

“That’s him,” she murmured ungrammatically.

Mr. Satterthwaite nodded quickly in comprehension. So this young Graham was the man of Madge’s choice. Well, she could hardly have done better as far as appearances went—and Mr. Satterthwaite was a shrewd observer. A pleasant, likeable, rather matter-of-fact young fellow. They’d make a nice pair—no nonsense about either of them—good healthy sociable young folk.

Laidell was run on old-fashioned lines. The ladies left the dining room first. Mr. Satterthwaite moved up to Graham and began to talk to him. His estimate of the young man was confirmed, yet there was something that struck him as being not quite true to type. Roger Graham was distraught, his mind seemed far away, his hand shook as he replaced the glass on the table.

“He’s got something on his mind,” thought Mr. Satterthwaite acutely. “Not nearly as important as he thinks it is, I dare say. All the same, I wonder what it is.”

Mr. Satterthwaite was in the habit of swallowing a couple of digestive pastilles after meals. Having neglected to bring them down with him, he went up to his room to fetch them.

On his way down to the drawing room, he passed along the long corridor on the ground floor. About halfway along it was a room known as the terrace room. As Mr. Satterthwaite looked through the open doorway in passing, he stopped short.

Moonlight was streaming into the room. The latticed panes gave it a queer rhythmic pattern. A figure was sitting on the low window sill, drooping a little sideways and softly twanging the string of a ukelele—not in a jazz rhythm, but in a far older rhythm, the beat of fairy horses riding on fairy hills.

Mr. Satterthwaite stood fascinated. She wore a dress of dull dark blue chiffon, ruched and pleated so that it looked like the feathers of a bird. She bent over the instrument crooning to it.

He came into the room—slowly, step by step. He was close to her when she looked up and saw him. She didn't start, he noticed, or seem surprised.

"I hope I'm not intruding," he began.

"Please—sit down."

He sat near her on a polished oak chair. She hummed softly under her breath.

"There's a lot of magic about tonight," she said. "Don't you think so?"

"Yes, there was a lot of magic about."

"They wanted me to fetch my uke," she explained. "And as I passed here, I thought it would be so lovely to be alone here—in the dark and the moon."

"Then I—" Mr. Satterthwaite half rose, but she stopped him.

"Don't go. You—you fit in, somehow. It's queer, but you do."

He sat down again.

"It's been a queer sort of evening," she said. "I was out in the woods late this afternoon, and I met a man—such a strange sort of man—tall and dark, like a lost soul. The sun was setting, and the light of it through the trees made him look like a kind of Harlequin."

"Ah!" Mr. Satterthwaite leant forward—his interest quickened.

"I wanted to speak to him—he—he looked so like somebody I know. But I lost him in the trees."

"I think I know him," said Mr. Satterthwaite.

"Do you? He is—interesting, isn't he?"

"Yes, he is interesting."

There was a pause. Mr. Satterthwaite was perplexed. There was something, he felt, that he ought to do—and he didn't know what it was. But surely—surely, it had to do with this girl. He said rather clumsily:

"Sometimes—when one is unhappy—one wants to get away—"

"Yes. That's true." She broke off suddenly. "Oh! I see what you mean. But you're wrong. It's just the other way round. I wanted to be alone because I'm happy."

"Happy?"

"Terribly happy."

She spoke quite quietly, but Mr. Satterthwaite had a sudden sense of shock. What this strange girl meant by being happy wasn't the same as Madge Keeley would have meant by the same words. Happiness, for Mabelle Annesley, meant some kind of intense and vivid ecstasy . . . something that was not only human, but more than human. He shrank back a little.

"I—didn't know," he said clumsily.

"Of course you couldn't. And it's not—the actual thing—I'm not happy yet—but I'm going to be." She leaned forward. "Do you know what it's like to stand in a wood—a big wood with dark shadows and trees very close all round you—a wood you might never get out of—and then, suddenly—just in front of you, you see the country of your dreams—shining and beautiful—you've only got to step out from the trees and the darkness and you've found it. . . ."

"So many things look beautiful," said Mr. Satterthwaite, "before we've reached them. Some of the ugliest things in the world look the most beautiful. . . ."

There was a step on the floor. Mr. Satterthwaite turned his head. A fair man with a stupid, rather wooden face, stood there. He was the man Mr. Satterthwaite had hardly noticed at the dinner-table.

"They're waiting for you, Mabelle," he said.

She got up, the expression had gone out of her face, her voice was flat and calm.

"I'm coming, Gerard," she said. "I've been talking to Mr. Satterthwaite."

She went out of the room, Mr. Satterthwaite following. He turned his head over his shoulder as he went and caught the expression on her husband's face. A hungry, despairing look.

"Enchantment," thought Mr. Satterthwaite. "He feels it right enough. Poor fellow—poor fellow."

The drawing room was well lighted. Madge and Doris Coles were vociferous in reproaches.

"Mabelle, you little beast—you've been ages."

She sat on a low stool, tuned the ukelele and sang. They all joined in.

"Is it possible," thought Mr. Satterthwaite, "that so many idiotic songs could have been written about My Baby."

But he had to admit that the syncopated wailing tunes were stirring. Though, of course, they weren't a patch on the old-fashioned waltz.

The air got very smoky. The syncopated rhythm went on.

"No conversation," thought Mr. Satterthwaite. "No good music. No *peace*." He wished the world had not become definitely so noisy.

Suddenly Mabelle Annesley broke off, smiled across the room at him, and began to sing a song of Grieg's.

"My swan—my fair one. . . ."

It was a favourite of Mr. Satterthwaite's. He liked the note of ingenuous surprise at the end.

"Wert only a swan then? A swan then?"

After that, the party broke up. Madge offered drinks whilst her father picked up the discarded ukelele and began twanging it absentmindedly. The party exchanged goodnights, drifted nearer and nearer to the door. Everyone talked at once. Gerard Annesley slipped away unostentatiously, leaving the others.

Outside the drawing room door, Mr. Satterthwaite bade Mrs. Graham a ceremonious goodnight. There were two staircases, one close at hand, the

other at the end of a long corridor. It was by the latter that Mr. Satterthwaite reached his room. Mrs. Graham and her son passed by the stairs near at hand whence the quiet Gerard Annesley had already preceded them.

"You'd better get your ukelele, Mabelle," said Madge. "You'll forget it in the morning if you don't. You've got to make such an early start."

"Come on, Mr. Satterthwaite," said Doris Coles, seizing him boisterously by one arm. "Early to bed—etcetera."

Madge took him by the other arm and all three ran down the corridor to peals of Doris's laughter. They paused at the end to wait for David Keeley, who was following at a much more sedate pace, turning out electric lights as he came. The four of them went upstairs together.

Mr. Satterthwaite was just preparing to descend to the diningroom for breakfast on the following morning, when there was a light tap on the door and Madge Keeley entered. Her face was dead white, and she was shivering all over.

"Oh, Mr. Satterthwaite."

"My dear child, what's happened?" He took her hand.

"Mabelle—Mabelle Annesley . . ."

"Yes?"

What had happened? What? Something terrible—he knew that. Madge could hardly get the words out.

"She—she hanged herself last night . . . On the back of her door. Oh! it's too horrible." She broke down—sobbing.

Hanged herself. Impossible. Incomprehensible!

He said a few soothing old-fashioned words to Madge, and hurried downstairs. He found David Keeley looking perplexed and incompetent.

"I've telephoned to the police, Satterthwaite. Apparently that's got to be done. So the doctor said. He's just finished examining the—the—good lord, it's a beastly business. She must have been desperately unhappy—to do it that way—Queer that song last night. Swan song, eh? She looked rather like a swan—a black swan."

"Yes."

"Swan Song," repeated Keeley. "Shows it was in her mind, eh?"

"It would seem so—yes, certainly it would seem so."

He hesitated, then asked if he might see—if, that is. . . .

His host comprehended the stammering request.

"If you want to—I'd forgotten you have a *penchant* for human tragedies."

He led the way up the broad staircase. Mr. Satterthwaite followed him. At the head of the stairs was the room occupied by Roger Graham and opposite it, on the other side of the passage, his mother's room. The latter door was ajar and a faint wisp of smoke floated through it.

A momentary surprise invaded Mr. Satterthwaite's mind. He had not judged Mrs. Graham to be a woman who smoked so early in the day. Indeed, he had had the idea that she did not smoke at all.

They went along the passage to the end door but one. David Keeley entered the room and Mr. Satterthwaite followed him.

The room was not a very large one and showed signs of a man's occupation. A door in the wall led into a second room. A bit of cut rope still dangled from a hook high up on the door. On the bed. . . .

Mr. Satterthwaite stood for a minute looking down on the heap of huddled chiffon. He noticed that it was ruched and pleated like the plumage of a bird. At the face, after one glance, he did not look again.

He glanced from the door with its dangling rope to the communicating door through which they had come.

"Was that open?"

"Yes. At least the maid says so."

"Annesley slept in there? Did he hear anything?"

"He says—nothing."

"Almost incredible," murmured Mr. Satterthwaite. He looked back at the form on the bed.

"Where is he?"

"Annesley? He's downstairs with the doctor."

They went downstairs to find an Inspector of police had arrived. Mr. Satterthwaite was agreeably surprised to recognize in him an old acquaintance, Inspector Winkfield. The Inspector went upstairs with the doctor, and a few minutes later a request came that all members of the house party should assemble in the drawing room.

The blinds had been drawn, and the whole room had a funereal aspect. Doris Coles looked frightened and subdued. Every now and then she dabbed her eyes with a handkerchief. Madge was resolute and alert, her

feelings fully under control by now. Mrs. Graham was composed, as always, her face grave and impassive. The tragedy seemed to have affected her son more keenly than anyone. He looked a positive wreck this morning. David Keeley, as usual, had subsided into the background.

The bereaved husband sat alone, a little apart from the others. There was a queer dazed look about him, as though he could hardly realize what had taken place.

Mr. Satterthwaite, outwardly composed, was inwardly seething with the importance of a duty shortly to be performed.

Inspector Winkfield, followed by Dr. Morris, came in and shut the door behind him. He cleared his throat and spoke.

"This is a very sad occurrence—very sad, I'm sure. It's necessary, under the circumstances, that I should ask everybody a few questions. You'll not object, I'm sure. I'll begin with Mr. Annesley. You'll forgive my asking, sir, but had your good lady ever threatened to take her life?"

Mr. Satterthwaite opened his lips impulsively, then closed them again. There was plenty of time. Better not speak too soon.

"I—no, I don't think so."

His voice was so hesitating, so peculiar, that everyone shot a covert glance at him.

"You're not sure, sir?"

"Yes—I'm—quite sure. She didn't."

"Ah! Were you aware that she was unhappy in any way?"

"No. I—no, I wasn't."

"She said nothing to you. About feeling depressed, for instance?"

"I—no, nothing."

Whatever the Inspector thought, he said nothing. Instead he proceeded to his next point.

"Will you describe to me briefly the events of last night?"

"We—all went up to bed. I fell asleep immediately and heard nothing. The housemaid's scream aroused me this morning. I rushed into the adjoining room and found my wife—and found her—"

His voice broke. The Inspector nodded.

"Yes, yes, that's quite enough. We needn't go into that. When did you last see your wife the night before?"

"I—downstairs."

“Downstairs?”

“Yes, we all left the drawing room together. I went straight up leaving the others talking in the hall.”

“And you didn’t see your wife again? Didn’t she say goodnight when she came up to bed?”

“I was asleep when she came up.”

“But she only followed you a few minutes later. That’s right, isn’t it, sir?” He looked at David Keeley, who nodded.

“She hadn’t come up half an hour later.”

Annesley spoke stubbornly. The Inspector’s eyes strayed gently to Mrs. Graham.

“She didn’t stay in your room talking, Madam?”

Did Mr. Satterthwaite fancy it, or was there a slight pause before Mrs. Graham said with her customary quiet decision of manner:

“No, I went straight into my room and closed the door. I heard nothing.”

“And you say, sir”—the Inspector had shifted his attention back to Annesley—“that you slept and heard nothing. The communicating door was open, was it not?”

“I—I believe so. But my wife would have entered her room by the other door from the corridor.”

“Even so, sir, there would have been certain sounds—a choking noise, a drumming of heels on the door—”

“No.”

It was Mr. Satterthwaite who spoke, impetuously, unable to stop himself. Every eye turned towards him in surprise. He himself became nervous, stammered, and turned pink.

“I—I beg your pardon, Inspector. But I must speak. You are on the wrong track—the wrong track altogether. Mrs. Annesley did not kill herself—I am sure of it. She was murdered.”

There was a dead silence, then Inspector Winkfield said quietly:

“What leads you to say that, sir?”

“I—it is a feeling. A very strong feeling.”

“But I think, sir, there must be more than that to it. There must be some particular reason.”

Well, of course there was a particular reason. There was the mysterious message from Mr. Quin. But you couldn’t tell a police inspector that. Mr.

Satterthwaite cast about desperately, and found nothing.

“Last night—when we were talking together, she said she was very happy. Very happy—just that. That wasn’t like a woman thinking of committing suicide.”

He was triumphant. He added:

“She went back to the drawing room to fetch her ukelele, so that she wouldn’t forget it in the morning. That didn’t look like suicide either.”

“No,” admitted the Inspector. “No, perhaps it didn’t.” He turned to David Keeley. “Did she take the ukelele upstairs with her?”

The mathematician tried to remember.

“I think—yes, she did. She went upstairs carrying it in her hand. I remember seeing it just as she turned the corner of the staircase before I turned off the light down here.”

“Oh!” cried Madge. “But it’s here now.”

She pointed dramatically to where the ukelele lay on a table.

“That’s curious,” said the Inspector. He stepped swiftly across and rang the bell.

A brief order sent the butler in search of the housemaid whose business it was to do the rooms in the morning. She came, and was quite positive in her answer. The ukelele had been there first thing that morning when she had dusted.

Inspector Winkfield dismissed her and then said curtly:

“I would like to speak to Mr. Satterthwaite in private, please. Everyone may go. But no one is to leave the house.”

Mr. Satterthwaite twittered into speech as soon as the door had closed behind the others.

“I—I am sure, Inspector, that you have the case excellently in hand. Excellently. I just felt that—having, as I say, a very strong feeling—”

The Inspector arrested further speech with an upraised hand.

“You’re quite right, Mr. Satterthwaite. The lady was murdered.”

“You knew it?” Mr. Satterthwaite was chagrined.

“There were certain things that puzzled Dr. Morris.” He looked across at the doctor, who had remained, and the doctor assented to his statement with a nod of the head. “We made a thorough examination. The rope that was round her neck wasn’t the rope that she was strangled with—it was something much thinner that did the job, something more like a wire. It had

cut right into the flesh. The mark of the rope was superimposed on it. She was strangled and then hung up on the door afterwards to make it look like suicide.”

“But who—?”

“Yes,” said the Inspector. “Who? That’s the question. What about the husband sleeping next door, who never said goodnight to his wife and who heard nothing? I should say we hadn’t far to look. Must find out what terms they were on. That’s where you can be useful to us, Mr. Satterthwaite. You’ve the *ongtray* here, and you can get the hang of things in a way we can’t. Find out what relations there were between the two.”

“I hardly like—” began Mr. Satterthwaite, stiffening.

“It won’t be the first murder mystery you’ve helped us with. I remember the case of Mrs. Strangeways. You’ve got a *flair* for that sort of thing, sir. An absolute *flair*.”

Yes, it was true—he *had a flair*. He said quietly:

“I will do my best, Inspector.”

Had Gerard Annesley killed his wife? Had he? Mr. Satterthwaite recalled that look of misery last night. He loved her—and he was suffering. Suffering will drive a man to strange deeds.

But there was something else—some other factor. Mabelle had spoken of herself as coming out of a wood—she was looking forward to happiness—not a quiet rational happiness—but a happiness that was irrational—a wild ecstasy . . .

If Gerard Annesley had spoken the truth, Mabelle had not come to her room till at least half an hour later than he had done. Yet David Keeley had seen her going up those stairs. There were two other rooms occupied in that wing. There was Mrs. Graham’s, and there was her son’s.

Her son’s. But he and Madge. . . .

Surely Madge would have guessed . . . But Madge wasn’t the guessing kind. All the same, no smoke without fire—Smoke!

Ah! he remembered. *A wisp of smoke curling out through Mrs. Graham’s bedroom door.*

He acted on impulse. Straight up the stairs and into her room. It was empty. He closed the door behind him and locked it.

He went across to the grate. A heap of charred fragments. Very gingerly he raked them over with his finger. His luck was in. In the very centre were

some unburnt fragments—fragments of letters . . .

Very disjointed fragments, but they told him something of value.

“Life can be wonderful, Roger darling. I never knew . . . all my life has been a dream till I met you, Roger. . . .”

“. . . Gerard knows, I think . . . I am sorry but what can I do? Nothing is real to me but you, Roger . . . We shall be together, soon.”

“What are you going to tell him at Laidell, Roger? You write strangely—but I am not afraid. . . .”

Very carefully, Mr. Satterthwaite put the fragments into an envelope from the writing table. He went to the door, unlocked it and opened it to find himself face to face with Mrs. Graham.

It was an awkward moment, and Mr. Satterthwaite was momentarily out of countenance. He did what was, perhaps, the best thing, attacked the situation with simplicity.

“I have been searching your room, Mrs. Graham. I have found something—a packet of letters imperfectly burnt.”

A wave of alarm passed over her face. It was gone in a flash, but it had been there.

“Letters from Mrs. Annesley to your son.”

She hesitated for a minute, then said quietly: “That is so. I thought they would be better burnt.”

“For what reason?”

“My son is engaged to be married. These letters—if they had been brought into publicity through the poor girl’s suicide—might have caused much pain and trouble.”

“Your son could burn his own letters.”

She had no answer ready for that. Mr. Satterthwaite pursued his advantage.

“You found these letters in his room, brought them into your room and burnt them. Why? You were afraid, Mrs. Graham.”

“I am not in the habit of being afraid, Mr. Satterthwaite.”

“No—but this was a desperate case.”

“Desperate?”

“Your son might have been in danger of arrest—for murder.”

“Murder!”

He saw her face go white. He went on quickly:

“You heard Mrs. Annesley go into your son’s room last night. He had told her of his engagement? No, I see he hadn’t. He told her then. They quarrelled, and he—”

“That’s a lie!”

They had been so absorbed in their duel of words that they had not heard approaching footsteps. Roger Graham had come up behind them unperceived by either.

“It’s all right, Mother. Don’t—worry. Come into my room, Mr. Satterthwaite.”

Mr. Satterthwaite followed him into his room. Mrs. Graham had turned away and did not attempt to follow them. Roger Graham shut the door.

“Listen, Mr. Satterthwaite, you think I killed Mabelle. You think I strangled her—here—and took her along and hung her up on that door—later—when everyone was asleep?”

Mr. Satterthwaite stared at him. Then he said surprisingly:

“No, I do not think so.”

“Thank God for that. I couldn’t have killed Mabelle. I—I loved her. Or didn’t I? I don’t know. It’s a tangle that I can’t explain. I’m fond of Madge—I always have been. And she’s such a good sort. We suit each other. But Mabelle was different. It was—I can’t explain it—a sort of enchantment. I was, I think—afraid of her.”

Mr. Satterthwaite nodded.

“It was madness—a kind of bewildering ecstasy . . . But it was impossible. It wouldn’t have worked. That sort of thing—doesn’t last. I know what it means now to have a spell cast over you.”

“Yes, it must have been like that,” said Mr. Satterthwaite thoughtfully.

“I—I wanted to get out of it all. I was going to tell Mabelle—last night.”

“But you didn’t?”

“No, I didn’t,” said Graham slowly. “I swear to you, Mr. Satterthwaite, that I never saw her after I said goodnight downstairs.”

“I believe you,” said Mr. Satterthwaite.

He got up. It was not Roger Graham who had killed Mabelle Annesley. He could have fled from her, but he could not have killed her. He had been afraid of her, afraid of that wild intangible fairy-like quality of hers. He had known enchantment—and turned his back on it. He had gone for the safe sensible thing that he had known “would work” and had relinquished the intangible dream that might lead him he knew not where.

He was a sensible young man, and, as such, uninteresting to Mr. Satterthwaite, who was an artist and a connoisseur in life.

He left Roger Graham in his room and went downstairs. The drawing room was empty. Mabelle’s ukelele lay on a stool by the window. He took it up and twanged it absentmindedly. He knew nothing of the instrument, but his ear told him that it was abominably out of tune. He turned a key experimentally.

Doris Coles came into the room. She looked at him reproachfully.

“Poor Mabelle’s uke,” she said.

Her clear condemnation made Mr. Satterthwaite feel obstinate.

“Tune it for me,” he said, and added: “If you can.”

“Of course I can,” said Doris, wounded at the suggestion of incompetence in any direction.

She took it from him, twanged a string, turned a key briskly—and the string snapped.

“Well, I never. Oh! I see—but how extraordinary! It’s the wrong string—a size too big. It’s an A string. How stupid to put that on. Of course it snaps when you try to tune it up. How stupid people are.”

“Yes,” said Mr. Satterthwaite. “They are—even when they try to be clever. . . .”

His tone was so odd that she stared at him. He took the ukelele from her and removed the broken string. He went out of the room holding it in his hand. In the library he found David Keeley.

“Here,” he said.

He held out the string. Keeley took it.

“What’s this?”

“A broken ukelele string.” He paused and then went on: “*What did you do with the other one?*”

“The other one?”

“The one you strangled her with. You were very clever, weren’t you? It was done very quickly—just in that moment we were all laughing and talking in the hall.

“Mabelle came back into this room for her ukelele. You had taken the string off as you fiddled with it just before. You caught her round the throat with it and strangled her. Then you came out and locked the door and joined us. Later, in the dead of night, you came down and—and disposed of the body by hanging it on the door of her room. And you put another string on the ukelele—but it was the wrong string, that’s why you were stupid.”

There was a pause.

“But why did you do it?” said Mr. Satterthwaite. *“In God’s name, why?”*

Mr. Keeley laughed, a funny giggling little laugh that made Mr. Satterthwaite feel rather sick.

“It was so very simple,” he said. *“That’s why! And then—nobody ever noticed me. Nobody ever noticed what I was doing. I thought—I thought I’d have the laugh of them. . . .”*

And again he gave that furtive little giggle and looked at Mr. Satterthwaite with mad eyes.

Mr. Satterthwaite was glad that at that moment Inspector Winkfield came into the room.

It was twenty-four hours later, on his way to London, that Mr. Satterthwaite awoke from a doze to find a tall dark man sitting opposite to him in the railway carriage. He was not altogether surprised.

“My dear Mr. Quin!”

“Yes—I am here.”

Mr. Satterthwaite said slowly: *“I can hardly face you. I am ashamed—I failed.”*

“Are you sure of that?”

“I did not save her.”

“But you discovered the truth?”

“Yes—that is true. One or other of those young men might have been accused—might even have been found guilty. So, at any rate, I saved a man’s life. But, she—she—that strange enchanting creature . . .” His voice broke off.

Mr. Quin looked at him.

“Is death the greatest evil that can happen to anyone?”

“I—well—perhaps—No. . . .”

Mr. Satterthwaite remembered . . . Madge and Roger Graham . . . Mabelle’s face in the moonlight—its serene unearthly happiness. . . .

“No,” he admitted. “No—perhaps death is not the greatest evil. . . .”

He remembered the ruffled blue chiffon of her dress that had seemed to him like the plumage of a bird . . . A bird with a broken wing. . . .

When he looked up, he found himself alone. Mr. Quin was no longer there.

But he had left something behind.

On the seat was a roughly carved bird fashioned out of some dim blue stone. It had, possibly, no great artistic merit. But it had something else.

It had the vague quality of enchantment.

So said Mr. Satterthwaite—and Mr. Satterthwaite was a connoisseur.

About the Author

AGATHA CHRISTIE is the most widely published author of all time, outsold only by the Bible and Shakespeare. Her books have sold more than a billion copies in English and another billion in a hundred foreign languages. She died in 1976.

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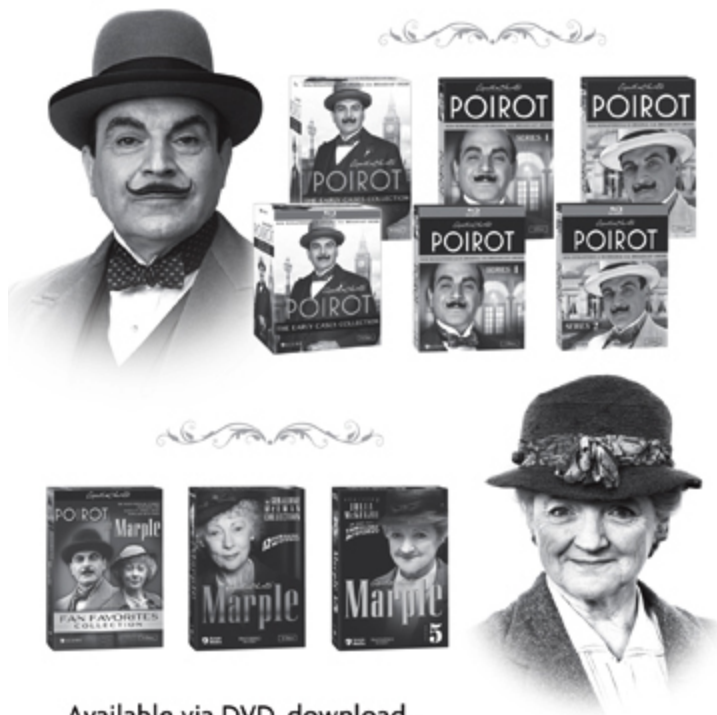
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EPub Edition OCTOBER 2013 ISBN: 9780062302342

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